have since learned, though Burnes said it was for the wandering tribes about to migrate'.[62]

Macnaghten, meanwhile, had been characteristically unfazed by the departure of his army commander, by the intelligence of intense arms manufacture in the bazaars or even by the angry exit of the Ghilzai chiefs, writing to Auckland that they were simply 'kicking up a row about some deductions which have been made from their pay' and would be 'well trounced for their pains . . . These fellows will require many a hiding yet,' he wrote, 'before they settle down into peaceable citizens.'[63]

The advance guard of Sale's brigade, around one thousand men, left Kabul on the morning of 9 October. They marched to Butkhak, a distance of fifteen miles from the cantonment on the Jalalabad road. That night, just after dark, as the troops were camped near the mouth of the pass, the sentries heard a strange sound echoing from the shadowy slopes and bare crags above them. Among the younger officers was Thomas Seaton, who was looking forward to returning to the pleasures of India.

> Our mess-dinner was just over, when the native officers commanding the quarter guard sent in a sepoy to tell the colonel that a great number of people were to be seen assembled on the hill above us, and that he had heard them loading their juzzails . . . The ball is put into juzzails naked, and requires to be hammered a great deal with an iron ramroad to get it home. This hammering makes a loud ringing noise, that can be heard at a considerable distance and so unmistakable in its character that it can never be forgotten by those whose ears have once been startled by the unfamiliar sound. 'Gentlemen,' said the colonel, 'you had better go and turn out your respective companies instantly, and as quietly as possible. They will be on you immediately.'

The Colonel sent parties round the camp to extinguish all the lights, and Seaton was ordered to take two companies to the foot of the hill where the Afghans were gathered, 'with directions to keep the men as silent as death; to make them kneel or sit down, and not to fire a shot' until the enemy descended from the hill. 'I marched off at the head of my men, and had scarcely reached my post when the whole hilltop seemed to burst into flame from the simultaneous discharge of hundreds of juzzails. Shouts and yells of "Yelli, Yelli, Yelli" [short for Ya Allah] at the same time rent the air, accompanied by howlings that would have done credit to a thousand jackals.' This onslaught was maintained for upwards of an hour.